THE BLACKHEARTS

Character Creation & Campaign Rules
Blood, Coin, and Betrayal

I. Character Creation

Starting Classes

All player characters begin at Level 1. Available starting classes are Fighter, Rogue, Ranger, Barbarian, and Monk.

Sorcerer, Wizard, Druid, Bard, and Psion are unavailable at character creation. They may become accessible through multiclassing after the character meets specific requirements, earns the necessary attainments, and completes appropriate training or questlines. Magic is rare and difficult to acquire.

Available Races

Human, Half-Orc, Dwarf, Elf, Half-Elf, Halfling, and Gnome. Racial variants, including Hill Dwarf and Mountain Dwarf, are subject to DM approval.

Ability Score Generation

Roll 4d4 + 4 separately for each of the six ability scores. Each score ranges from 8 to 20, with an average of 14. This method produces generally above-average characters while preserving randomness.

Backgrounds and Feats

Most standard backgrounds are available at the DM’s discretion. Custom backgrounds are welcome with DM approval. A list of acceptable feats will be supplied at character creation. Players seeking an unlisted feat may present it to the DM and explain how it fits their character.

II. Backstories & Individual Sessions

Required Character Backstories

Every player must prepare a concise written introduction to their character. It need not be a book, but should explain:

- Who the character is and where they came from.
- Their strengths, weaknesses, flaws, and personality.
- The events that shaped their worldview.
- Their outlook on morality, religion, and the world, and why they hold those views.
- Their motivations and reasons for joining the Blackhearts.

Individual Introduction Sessions

Before the main campaign begins, each player will have a private session with the DM to establish their character in the setting and introduce their path into the Blackhearts. Additional solo sessions may occur later for personal storylines, roleplaying, training, and level-up quests.

III. Character Advancement & Training

Experience Does Not Automatically Grant Levels

Reaching the experience requirement makes a character eligible to level up; it does not grant the level automatically. To advance, the character must find and contact an appropriate class trainer and successfully complete an assigned quest, task, or challenge.

Failure & Advancement Restrictions

If the character fails, they remain at their current level until they successfully complete an advancement quest offered by an appropriate trainer. Advancement must be earned in the world, not simply claimed on the character sheet.

Advanced Class Attainment

Magical and specialized classes require additional achievements, opportunities, and training. Sufficient experience or ability scores alone do not guarantee access.

IV. Equipment, Magic & Crafting

The Rarity of Magic

Magical weapons, armor, artifacts, and other enchanted objects are exceptionally rare and highly prized. Players should not expect to find them regularly. Instead, much of their equipment progression will come from superior materials, skilled artisans, and custom craftsmanship.

The Crafting System

Weapons, armor, and other items may be crafted through a d100 roll, modified by material quality, the skill of the crafter, special components, and the intended design. Finished items fall into five quality categories: Poor, Fair, Good, Masterwork, and Incredible.

Example: A Specialized Shortsword

A player commissions a shortsword using high-quality iron, hires a master swordsmith, and supplies a ruby for the pommel. For an extra fee, they request a serrated blade that, if successfully crafted, adds 1d2 bleeding damage on a hit.

Crafting factor	Modifier
High-quality iron	+10%
Master swordsmith	+25%
Ruby embellishment	+5%
Total modifier	**+40%**

The player rolls 40 on the d100. With the +40% modifier, the final result is 80%—just enough for Masterwork quality.

Crafting Limitations

Materials and the crafter's capabilities impose a ceiling on the finished item's quality. Even a legendary smith can do only so much with poor-quality copper. Detailed quality thresholds, special features, and material rules will be supplied later. Ask the DM about unusual crafting ideas.

V. Advanced Combat Rules

Combat will use expanded tactical rules to make encounters deadlier and reward preparation, positioning, and teamwork. The following systems will apply:

- Deadly Criticals: Expanded percentile-based critical effects.
- Flanking: Advantages for coordinated positioning.
- Elevation & Distance: Modifiers for height and range.
- Called Shots: Targeted attacks with additional difficulty and potential effects.
- Cover: Defensive benefits from terrain and obstacles.
- Darkness & Brightness: Visibility and lighting effects.
- Weather: Environmental effects from wind, rain, fog, snow, and more.

Detailed combat mechanics will be provided before play.

VI. Final Considerations

The Blackhearts is a challenging, grimdark campaign where choices have consequences and advancement must be earned. Characters begin as little-known initiates in a dangerous criminal organization. Resourcefulness, ambition, alliances, and survival will matter as much as prowess in combat.

Not every encounter is meant to be won by force. Not every enemy should be confronted immediately. Not every contract is what it seems.

Preparation matters. Reputation matters. Loyalty matters. Above all, survival matters.

Welcome to the Blackhearts. Earn your place, or make room for someone who will.